A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Philemon 8–19

A Comprehensive Appeal

The Epistle to Philemon

Small Group Bible Study Series · Philemon · Study 2 of 3

Source: Dr. C Norman Sellers ThD sellersbibleinstitute.com (used by permission)
Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Philemon 8–19

8 *Therefore, though I might be very bold in Christ to command you what is fitting,*

9 *yet for love's sake I rather appeal to you—being such a one as Paul, the aged, and now also a prisoner of Jesus Christ—*

10 *I appeal to you for my son Onesimus, whom I have begotten while in my chains,*

11 *who once was unprofitable to you, but now is profitable to you and to me.*

12 *I am sending him back. You therefore receive him, that is, my own heart,*

13 *whom I wished to keep with me, that on your behalf he might minister to me in my chains for the gospel.*

14 *But without your consent I wanted to do nothing, that your good deed might not be by compulsion, as it were, but voluntary.*

15 *For perhaps he departed for a while for this purpose, that you might receive him forever,*

16 *no longer as a slave but more than a slave—a beloved brother, especially to me but how much more to you, both in the flesh and in the Lord.*

17 *If then you count me as a partner, receive him as you would me.*

18 *But if he has wronged you or owes anything, put that on my account.*

19 *I, Paul, am writing with my own hand. I will repay—not to mention to you that you owe me even your own self besides.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *"If then you count me as a partner, receive him as you would me. But if he has wronged you or owes anything, put that on my account. — Philemon 17–18"*

"A man who would have friends must himself be friendly." Friends don't come by osmosis. Paul had his moments — he once parted company with Barnabas over John Mark — but by the time he wrote to Philemon he had learned something. He was walking on eggshells to say it right. He could have commanded; for love's sake he appealed.

And look what he asks. Not only "no longer as a slave," but "more than a slave — a beloved brother," and finally, "receive him as you would me." Then Paul reaches for his own ledger: "If he has wronged you or owes anything, put that on my account. I will repay."

That is a picture of what Jesus did for us. We owed a debt we could not pay. On the cross He said, in effect, "Put it on My account," and He paid a debt He did not owe. People who have been treated like that can afford to be friendly.

Reflect

1. Where are you tempted to use your rights instead of making an appeal for love's sake?
2. Who is the "Onesimus" in your life — someone you need to receive as a brother or sister?
3. How does knowing that Christ put your debt on His account change the way you treat those who owe you?

I owed a debt I could not pay; He paid a debt He did not owe.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Paul, now the soul of tact, does not command Philemon but appeals to him along three lines — necessity, responsibility, and liability — asking him to receive Onesimus no longer as a slave but as a beloved brother, even as he would receive Paul, and offering to pay whatever is owed: a picture of what Christ has done for us.

Introduction

He Who Would Have Friends … – Proverbs 18:24

Be friendly and you'll have friends. That's what we're talking about today. This is in Philemon, verses 8 through 19. "He who would have friends must show himself friendly."

I heard this verse the first time when I went to college — old farm boy up in Philadelphia. The first thing I heard at the orientation was from Dr. Clarence Mason, who was the academic dean. And he said, "Let me suggest something to you. No — let me tell you something about your life. When you're here in college, you're meeting all new friends. All your old friends are back home. Now you have new people here." He said, "Here's a verse I want you to see, and I want you to hear and use." And the verse was Proverbs 18:24. And it reads like this:

> *"A man who would have friends must himself be friendly, but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother."*

That's it. Our friendship will attract other people. If you want friends, be friendly. That's the key. Well, friends don't come by osmosis. There are some prerequisites. And the major one is: friendliness produces friends.

Paul Had His Moments – Acts 15:36

Paul had his moments on this friend stuff. Back in Acts chapter 15, verse 36 — remember, Paul had gone on the first missionary journey prior to that. One day he got thinking about all the people that they met on that first missionary journey. "Let's go back." And so he found Barnabas. "Let's go back to these people. Let's see them, see how they're doing." And Barnabas said, "Oh, great. I'll go get my cousin — or nephew, whichever. I'll get my cousin, John Mark." And Paul said, "No way. John Mark's not going with us."

Why would that be? Well, because John Mark left them in the middle of the work. In fact, going on to the continent to get the work done, he left. He went back home to mama. Paul didn't like that. Paul said, "He will not go with us." And it was the cousin of Barnabas. Barnabas said, "Well, he's going to go with me." And so they split up, and they went two different ways. But to me, it even says that the feeling was so strong between them that they parted company. Now, that's not friendly. That is bad. But at the same time, the Lord used that.

And then later on, Paul was reconciled to both of them. With John Mark — in Colossians 4, verse 10, Paul says this. He said, "Mark the cousin of Barnabas (about whom you received instructions: if he comes to you, welcome him)." Wow. Paul learned something. And

Barnabas — same thing. In 1 Corinthians 9:6 he says, “Or is it only Barnabas and I who have no right to refrain from working?” Only just the two of us — he puts himself with Barnabas. Barnabas is one like me. Well, he’s back with them. But don’t forget, there was a problem there. He had a problem, and he got on the wrong side of them.

So — but even if he was wrong in that case, this section here shows that toward the end of his ministry Paul was the soul of tact. He learned something in his life. He learned how to be friendly. He learned how to have friends. He learned how to treat friends. He was walking on eggshells when he was writing this to Philemon and telling him about Onesimus and all that. He was walking on eggshells to do the right thing, to say it right — to keep from telling Philemon what to do.

And he approached Philemon along three lines of argument: the necessities, the responsibilities, and the liabilities — Necessity, Responsibility, Liability.

I. Along the Line of Necessity – vv. 8–13

First of all, he talked about the necessities, in verses 8 through 13.

A. Paul Gives His Rights – v. 8

> *“Therefore, though I might be very bold in Christ to command you what is fitting,”*

Verse 8: Paul gives his rights. Verse 8: “Therefore, though I might be very bold in Christ to command you what is fitting” — Paul, an apostle. “I could be bold if I wanted to. That’s my right. I’m an apostle. I can tell you what to do.”

And Paul was apostle number 13. Matthias was number 12. And Judas — number nothing. He’d been thrown out. But Paul was an apostle. No doubt about it. He was the apostle to these Gentiles. He was their apostle.

And so we need to know who we are, and what rights we have. Paul knew who he was. “I have rights. And I’m not saying, ‘Oh, I’m some little thing cowering over here somewhere.’ No, I have rights. I know what my rights are.” We should. We should be confident in who we are in Christ. And then we ought to recognize that we are in Christ. At the same time, we must stress that our rights are “in Christ.” It’s in Christ. And in Christ, I’m nothing. He is everything. “But I have these rights”? No.

B. Paul Gives Up His Rights – vv. 9–13

So Paul gives his rights. But then, in verses 9 through 13, Paul gives up his rights. Oh, wow. How many friends are you going to get when you’re forcing people to do things, like Paul? No. None. That’s what Paul did back in the earlier days. But now he’s saying, “No, I’ll give up my rights.”

1. In Favor of Higher Ground – v. 9

> *“yet for love’s sake I rather appeal to you—being such a one as Paul, the aged, and now also a prisoner of Jesus Christ—“*

He’s doing this in favor of the higher ground. “I’m going to the higher ground. ‘Oh, we’re having problems down here.’ No — I’m going to the higher ground. I’m up here. For love’s sake I rather appeal to you. I could force you to do this, right? Amen? But no, sir, I’m going

to ask you. I'm going to appeal to you. And I'm doing this now not because of apostleship. I'm telling you because I'm Paul the aged." Oh, I can almost hear him say, "Paul the old. I'm so old. And I'm a prisoner of Jesus Christ." That's what he's coming to. "That's where I am. I'm appealing on that basis."

Aged. And you say, "Well, how old was Paul?" Well, at this time, Paul was 57. Old man! Just a kid. The average life expectancy, though, in that time was from 50 to 60 (Wikipedia). So he was approaching it. He lived another five years, so he was 62 when he died. But Paul was an old man in that case.

Prisoner. And he was a prisoner. Notice he says a prisoner of Jesus. He wasn't a prisoner of Rome. He wasn't a prisoner of the Jews — not of Rome or Jerusalem. A prisoner of Jesus. He was there for Jesus' sake. So he was showing the higher ground that he took. It's a lot better to ask somebody to do things from this level than to force them to do it from this level. Can't do that.

2. In Favor of Higher Gains – vv. 10–11

So he also said, "I want to do this in favor of higher gains."

a. I Gained a New Son – v. 10

> *"I appeal to you for my son Onesimus, whom I have begotten while in my chains,"*

I gained a new son. Verse 10: "I appeal to you for my son" — that is, my own child. He only uses this two other times, when he was referring to Timothy and Titus. Those three are his sons. "My own son," he said, "whom I have begotten." Paul probably led him to faith in Christ, "while in my chains." Remember, Onesimus ran away from Philemon, and he went to Rome to hide in the crowd. And the Lord knew where he was, and pulled him out, and got him over to Paul. Paul led him to the Lord.

Well, he didn't have many opportunities to do that on a one-on-one basis in prison, but here was one he had. And that was his own son, his special son. And he did have contact with him all the time. He had a good relationship with Onesimus. If I have no more contact with him, we have had a good relationship.

b. You Gained a New Slave – v. 11

> *"who once was unprofitable to you, but now is profitable to you and to me."*

And then he says, "I gained something. Now you gained too. You gained a new slave, who once was unprofitable to you, but now is profitable to you and to me" — both of us. The greatest gain went to Philemon. He receives his slave back — with interest. He had gained his slave back, but now he's not just a slave of Philemon. He's a slave of Jesus Christ. He's going to serve Him.

And if you serve wherever you are — in your job, whatever relationships you have — if you serve the Lord, then you have to do what people over you say. But if you do it, you say, "Well, okay, I'm serving the Lord. Lord, I'm going to do this for You." How hard is that? So Onesimus is now going to be a servant of Jesus Christ under Philemon.

Now, the word "Onesimus" means "useful." And Paul is using a literary device called paronomasia — that is, using a play on words. We have a little different word for that today

— a much shorter word for the same device. We call it a pun. So I make the play on words, and you say, “Oh, that’s a pun.” Well, we used to say back in my day, when somebody gave a pun like that, “Oh, that’s two-thirds of a pun — P-U.” Anyway, he was doing a pun here, a paronomasia. And he was saying he was going from unprofitable to — now he is profitable. That’s him.

So the word is: for Onesimus, then, he says “unprofitable,” and then “now he is profitable.” Paul uses the Greek word χρηστός. Onesimus the unprofitable (ἄχρηστον) — now, both to you and to me, profitable (εὔχρηστον). Just the same word, except the letters on the front make the difference.

3. In Favor of Higher Goals – vv. 12–13

Now — so he’s going to higher ground. He’s going for higher gain, with his paronomasia. And then he was doing it in favor of higher goals.

a. For Philemon: Receiving or Not Receiving – v. 12

> *“I am sending him back. You therefore receive him, that is, my own heart,”*

For Philemon: receiving or not receiving. Are you going to receive him back? Philemon, receive the slave back? He ran away from you, stole money from you — you’re going to take him back? “I am sending him back. Therefore receive him, that is, my own heart” — the guy who is closest to my heart. Receive him as you would me. So Philemon could — he could kill him. You could kill a runaway slave in those days. And he could mistreat him, could whip him, do all kinds of things. But he says, “No, you take him back as you would me.”

b. For Paul: Retaining or Not Retaining – v. 13

> *“whom I wished to keep with me, that on your behalf he might minister to me in my chains for the gospel.”*

Then for Paul, the question was: shall I send him, or shall I keep him here? Shall I retain him or not retain him? He says in verse 13, “whom I wished to keep with me, that on your behalf he might minister to me in my chains for the gospel.” “I’d like to keep him here.” Paul wanted to keep him. No question about that. But he’s going to serve someone — why not Paul? Paul’s the one who turned him around. Paul’s the one who made him a profitable servant. Why shouldn’t he do that?

But then Paul chose to forgo that — his own desires, his own necessity. His necessity — “I’m going to let that go. I’m going to go on to other things.” So those are his necessities.

II. Along the Line of Responsibility – vv. 14–17

And then he argues along the lines of responsibility, 14 to 17.

A. The Duty of Responsibility – Legal Restoration – v. 14

> *“But without your consent I wanted to do nothing, that your good deed might not be by compulsion, as it were, but voluntary.”*

The responsibility of Paul was a legal restoration. The slave belonged to Philemon. Paul could have kept him, but he said, “No, I’m going to send him back. Without your consent,”

verse 14, “I wanted to do nothing, that your good deed might not be by compulsion, as it were, but voluntary.”

See, if Paul had kept him — had kept Onesimus there with him — then Philemon would have no say in the matter. So he would be giving him up, but not willingly. So Paul said, “I’m sending him back to you.” I think Paul was hoping that Philemon would send him back, so that he could be Paul’s helper. But he said, “I won’t do that. I won’t keep him. If you want to send him back, good.” So if he kept him, he would make Philemon’s decision for him. What choice would he have? Of course. So Philemon has a choice, then. If he wants to send him back, he can do it. Paul may not get his way, but that is the risk of tact.

B. The Responsibility of Onesimus – Life Redemption – v. 15

> *“For perhaps he departed for a while for this purpose, that you might receive him forever,”*

But then there’s another responsibility — the responsibility of Philemon — I’m sorry, of Onesimus: his life redemption, verse 15. “For perhaps he departed for a while for this purpose, that you might receive him forever.” His life has changed. Out of gratitude he should serve not only his human master, but serve his spiritual Master, Jesus Christ. His whole life is going to change now. He’ll still be a slave, as far as we know, but he’s going to do it from a different angle. That’s his responsibility: change his life — turn his life around through Jesus Christ.

C. The Responsibility of Philemon – Love Relationship – vv. 16–17

And then the responsibility of Philemon: a love relationship.

1. The Negative – v. 16a

> *“no longer as a slave”*

On the negative side: he’s no longer a slave. “Receive him no longer as a slave.” Legally, he may still claim that Onesimus is still his property. Legally, yes. But human laws are not the ultimate law. So he’s saying to him, the negative side is: receive him not as a slave.

2. The Positive – v. 16b

> *“but more than a slave—a beloved brother, especially to me but how much more to you, both in the flesh and in the Lord.”*

But then the positive side is 16b: “but more than a slave — a beloved brother.” Whoa, that’s a big difference. “A beloved brother, especially to me but how much more to you, both in the flesh and in the Lord.” He now is more than a slave — to Paul and to Philemon; in the flesh and in the Lord. He is more than a slave. He’s a brother.

3. The Superlative – v. 17

> *“If then you count me as a partner, receive him as you would me.”*

And then the superlative there. Negative, positive, superlative. Verse 17: “If then you count me as a partner, receive him as you would me.” Well, this goes one step farther. That’s the ultimate. “Receive him as you would me.” No longer a slave; much more than a slave; now

the same as you would if the apostle Paul came. How great is that? You wouldn't put Paul in chains. Don't put him in chains. That's a great change for him.

III. Along the Line of Liability – vv. 18–19

Now, that's the necessities, the responsibilities. Now, the liability. Along the lines of liability he's arguing, verses 18 and 19.

A. What Was Owed to Philemon – vv. 18–19a

> *"But if he has wronged you or owes anything, put that on my account. I, Paul, am writing with my own hand. I will repay—"*

What was owed to Philemon? That's first. "If he wronged you or owes you anything, put that on my account. I will repay." "I'm ready to repay you." What would Paul have to do with this? Remember — Paul the apostle. No, no. "No, I'll even pay his bills." That's great.

How great is this? "You don't lose a thing, Philemon. You lost a slave. Money [he took] from you — I'll pay you. All the time he's away, you haven't had his services — I'll pay you that too. Just put it on my account." It's a bookkeeping thing. Whatever he stole — Paul will pay. Whatever time he was away — Paul will pay.

Well, this is a non-theological picture of imputation. We owed God a tremendous debt. We had no way to pay it. Jesus died on the cross. He paid all our sin debt. And He said to the Father on the cross — in effect — "Whatever he or she owes, I'll pay it." For the whole world. Not limited — unlimited. He died for the world. And Jesus Christ on the cross is doing the same thing that Paul did here: "Whatever he owes, I'll pay it." And Jesus said, "Whatever anybody owes — I'll pay it. I'll pay the price." He did that. And He did it voluntarily, of course. He said, "Put it on My account. I'll pay it." And He did. As 2 Corinthians 5:21 says:

> *"For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him."*

That's it. That's the picture. I was riding on the highway, and I don't know how I got next to a truck. And I saw on the side of the truck something I'll never forget. It said this: "I owed a debt I could not pay; He paid a debt He did not owe." That's it. That's what Paul's saying. Onesimus owes this debt. "I'll pay it, because I can do it."

So the Father did this only with His Son's willingness to do so, of course. He says in Hebrews [10:7]:

> *"Then I said, 'Behold, I have come—in the volume of the book it is written of Me—to do Your will, O God.'"*

So Paul is really putting himself in debt to Philemon. He's saying, "Put that in my ledger." I don't know too much about bookkeeping, but there's a debit side and a credit side. Here's the debit side; here's your credit side. He's saying, "Okay, put all that — all that he owes you — on my debit side." On the debit side of my page in your ledger: "Paul the apostle — debit." Look for all the stuff Onesimus owes Philemon. Yeah. That's what he owed.

B. What Was Owed by Philemon – v. 19b

> *"—not to mention to you that you owe me even your own self besides."*

Now, that's what was owed to Philemon — that's what was owed to him. Now, what was owed by him. Then he says in verse 19b — this is so subtle. You say, "Man, what happened to Paul here?" Paul says, "I'm not going to mention that you owe me even your own self besides."

Well, now he's going to come over to the credit side. How much credit does Paul have with Philemon? Oh, a lot of credit. Your whole life on this side — the little debt that Onesimus owed on that one. "Now look what you owe me." He brings the iron fist in a little bit, but he puts it in a velvet glove. He brings up the credit side of his page in the ledger, just to balance the whole thing. "While you're there," he says — "while you're there working on my debit side — check the credit side. See where I am. Check on how much credit I have."

Conclusion

Now, what I want us to see is this. The apostle Paul could have wondered: "What are you doing here? You should be taking him back. I demand you take him back." No, no. You think those two would have been friends after that? No, no. "I am appealing to you — not as the great apostle: 'You have to do this.' No. What I'm saying to you is, please do it. I'm giving you good reasons for doing it, but I'm not saying you have to do it."

They're friends. They were friends after that, I'm sure. I have friends today in heaven. They're sitting up there saying, "Hey, look, there's a guy down there preaching about us." Because he was friendly. You'll have friends.

People will not always do things the way you want them to do it. They don't always do things right. "Nobody talked to me today." How many did you talk to? Show yourself friendly. And as you do that, then there'll be friends, because the friendly person's going to get the friends.

I really think that the apostle Paul — he's done a lot of good theological stuff here, a lot of practical stuff too. "He who would have friends must show himself friendly, and there is a friend that sticks closer than a brother." And that's Jesus Christ. What a friend we have in Jesus. If I'd known earlier in the week exactly what we were going to get here, we would have been singing "What a Friend We Have in Jesus" right now. That's it.

So let's take a page out of Paul's book. Let's be a friendly person. And then we'll be a friendly church. And then we'll be more like that Friend we have in Jesus.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.8	**παρρησίαν** *boldness*	G3954 *parrēsia* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	THAY: freedom in speaking, confidence. Significance: as an apostle Paul had every right to speak boldly and "command" — and he chose not to.
v.8	**ἐπιτάσσειν** *to command*	G2004 *epitassō* Pres. Act. Inf.	STR: to arrange upon, enjoin, order. Significance: the word of authority Paul sets aside in favor of an appeal.
v.9	**ἀγάπην** *love*	G26 *agapē* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	Significance: "for love's sake" — the higher ground. Paul appeals on the basis of love, not apostleship.
v.9	**παρακαλῶ** *I appeal*	G3870 *parakaleō* Pres. Act. Ind. 1st Sg.	STR: to call alongside, beseech, exhort. VINE: ranges from comfort to earnest entreaty. Significance: repeated in v. 10 — Paul asks rather than orders.
v.9	**πρεσβύτης** *the aged*	G4246 *presbytēs* N-Nom. Sg. Masc.	STR: an old man. Significance: Paul appeals as "Paul the aged" and a prisoner of Jesus Christ, not as an apostle. (Some scholars read the related *presbeutēs*, "ambassador"; the NKJV reads "aged.")
v.10	**τέκνου** *son, child*	G5043 *teknon* N-Gen. Sg. Neut.	STR: a child. Significance: "my son … whom I have begotten" — Paul's spiritual son, as he speaks of Timothy and Titus.
v.10	**ἐγέννησα** *I have begotten*	G1080 *gennaō* Aor. Act. Ind. 1st Sg.	STR: to beget, bring forth. Significance: Paul probably led Onesimus to faith in Christ "while in my chains."
v.11	**ἄχρηστον** *unprofitable*	G890 *achrēstos* Adj.-Acc. Sg. Masc.	MRV: useless. Significance: the pun (paronomasia) on Onesimus' name, "useful" — once useless to Philemon.
v.11	**εὔχρηστον** *profitable*	G2173 *euchrēstos* Adj.-Acc. Sg. Masc.	STR: easily used, serviceable. Significance: same root χρηστός; only the prefix changes — now useful "to you and to me."
v.12	**σπλάγχνα** *my own heart*	G4698 *splanchna* N-Acc. Pl. Neut.	STR: the inward parts, the affections. Significance: Onesimus is the one closest to Paul's heart — "receive him as you would me."
v.14	**ἀνάγκην** *compulsion*	G318 *anankē* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: necessity, constraint. Significance: Paul will not make Philemon's decision for him; the good deed must be voluntary.
v.16	**ἀδελφὸν ἀγαπητόν** *beloved brother*	G80 / G27 *adelphos agapētos* N-Acc. Sg. Masc. + Adj.	Significance: the positive — "more than a slave," a brother both in the flesh and in the Lord.

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.17	**κοινωνόν** *partner*	G2844 *koinōnos* N-Acc. Sg. Masc.	STR: a sharer, partner. Significance: the superlative — receive Onesimus as you would Paul himself.
v.18	**ἐλλόγα** *put on my account*	G1677 *ellogaō* Pres. Act. Impv. 2nd Sg.	THAY: to reckon in, charge to one's account. ATR: a commercial term. Significance: a non-theological picture of imputation (2 Cor. 5:21).
v.19	**ἀποτίσω** *I will repay*	G661 *apotinō* Fut. Act. Ind. 1st Sg.	STR: to pay in full. Significance: written "with my own hand" — Paul's signed promissory note.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Sources: STR = Strong's · THAY = Thayer's · ATR = A.T. Robertson, Word Pictures · VINE = Vine's · MRV = Vincent's Word Studies · LXX = Septuagint usage. Parsing: Blue Letter Bible.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
What verse opens the message, and what does it teach?	Proverbs 18:24 — a man who would have friends must himself be friendly. Friends don't come by osmosis; friendliness produces friends.
When did Paul "have his moments"?	Acts 15:36 — he parted company with Barnabas over John Mark, though later he was reconciled to both (Col. 4:10; 1 Cor. 9:6).
What are Paul's three lines of argument?	Necessity (vv. 8–13), Responsibility (vv. 14–17), and Liability (vv. 18–19).
What pun does Paul use in v. 11?	Onesimus means "useful"; once *achrēstos* (unprofitable), now *euchrēstos* (profitable) — a paronomasia.
What are the negative, positive, and superlative in vv. 16–17?	No longer a slave; more than a slave — a beloved brother; receive him as you would me.
What does v. 18 picture?	Imputation: as Paul says "put that on my account," Christ paid a debt He did not owe (2 Cor. 5:21).

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. **Paul says he could "be very bold in Christ to command." Why does he appeal instead?**

   > *Leader note: For love's sake he takes the higher ground. Forcing people does not make friends; appealing to them does. Paul knew his rights but gave them up.*

2. **Why does Paul send Onesimus back rather than keep him (vv. 13–14)?**

   > *Leader note: Keeping him would make Philemon's decision for him. Paul wanted Philemon's good deed to be voluntary, not by compulsion — even at the risk of not getting his way.*

3. **How does Onesimus' changed life affect his service (v. 15)?**

> *Leader note: Out of gratitude he should serve not only his human master but his spiritual Master, Jesus Christ — still a slave as far as we know, but serving from a different angle.*

4. **How is v. 18 a picture of what Christ did for us?**

> *Leader note: We owed a debt we could not pay. On the cross Jesus said, in effect, "Put it on My account," and paid for the whole world, voluntarily (2 Cor. 5:21; Heb. 10:7).*

5. **What is the "iron fist in a velvet glove" in v. 19b?**

> *Leader note: Paul brings up the credit side of the ledger — Philemon owes Paul his own self — but he does it gently: "not to mention."*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
vv. 8–13	Along the Line of Necessity	Paul gives his rights, then gives them up — for higher ground (love), higher gains (a new son, a profitable slave), and higher goals.
vv. 14–17	Along the Line of Responsibility	Paul will not decide for Philemon; Onesimus is changed; Philemon must receive him as a brother — as Paul himself.
vv. 18–19	Along the Line of Liability	"Put that on my account. I will repay" — and, not to mention, you owe me your own self.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Show Yourself Friendly

Proverbs 18:24

Drawn from Commentary Introduction and Conclusion and Devotional ②.

Friends don't come by osmosis. Paul had his moments, but he learned how to be friendly, how to have friends, and how to treat friends. "Nobody talked to me today." How many did you talk to?

Reflection: Are you waiting for others to be friendly to you first?

Practical Step: This Sunday, speak first to two people you do not usually talk to.

Application 2 — Appeal, Don't Command

Philemon 8–9

Drawn from Commentary I.A–B and Study Question 1.

Paul knew who he was and what rights he had in Christ — and for love's sake he gave them up to make an appeal. How many friends are you going to get when you are forcing people to do things?

Reflection: In what relationship are you relying on your rights or position instead of love?

Practical Step: Turn one demand you plan to make this week into a request, and give good reasons rather than orders.

Application 3 — Receive Him as You Would Me

Philemon 16–17

Drawn from Commentary II.C and Greek Word Study (κοινωνός).

No longer a slave; more than a slave — a beloved brother; receive him as you would Paul. Human laws are not the ultimate law. In Christ, the person who wronged you can become a brother.

Reflection: Is there someone who wronged you whom the Lord is asking you to receive as a brother or sister?

Practical Step: Take one step toward that person — a call, a note, or a kind word.

Application 4 — Put It on My Account

Philemon 18; 2 Corinthians 5:21

Drawn from Commentary III.A and Greek Word Study (ἐλλογάω).

"I owed a debt I could not pay; He paid a debt He did not owe." Jesus put our debt on His account. People who have been forgiven that much can cover the debts of others.

Reflection: Whose debt against you are you still keeping on the books?

Practical Step: Thank the Lord specifically for paying your debt, and then cancel one debt you are holding against someone else.

End of Study · Philemon 8–19